
Opsec for activists and journalists

A standalone handout from Day 2, Session 7. Print it, translate it, hand it out.

This is for people who may be targeted for what they say or who they support:

activists, organisers, independent journalists, and the groups that fund them.

Bitcoin can let you receive support that a bank cannot freeze. But Bitcoin is

not magic and not invisible. Used carelessly, it can expose you. Used with a

few steady habits, it protects you.

Privacy is not about hiding wrongdoing. It is the right to exist, organise and

report without asking permission.

Why this matters here

Across the continent, money has been used as a quiet weapon. A few real examples:

- **Nigeria, 2020 (#EndSARS):** organisers' bank accounts were frozen and donation apps flagged protest funds. Movements turned to Bitcoin to keep going.
- **Kenya, 2024 (Finance Bill protests):** fundraisers were delayed under "security review" and some mobile-money transfers were blocked or reversed.
- **Zimbabwe and Sudan:** inflation, blocked remittances and audits were used to exhaust civil society and independent media.

The lesson is not "Bitcoin fixes everything." It is "the system you rely on can be turned off, so know how to hold value that cannot be turned off, and learn to use it safely."

The one thing to understand first

Bitcoin is pseudonymous, not anonymous. Every on-chain transaction is public

and permanent. Your name is not on it, but patterns can link addresses to you, especially if you reuse an address or cash out through a service that knows your identity. So privacy must be **practised**, not assumed.

Seven habits that protect you

1. **Never reuse an address.** Use a wallet that makes a new address for every payment (most modern wallets do). A reused address is like printing your name on every receipt you ever hand out.

1. ****Never share a screenshot of your wallet, your balance, or your extended public key (xpub).**** The xpub can reveal all your past and future addresses.

1. **Separate your wallets by purpose.** Keep one wallet for donations, another for day-to-day spending, another for savings. Do not mix funds between them.

1. **Prefer Lightning for small and frequent payments.** Lightning payments are not written to the public blockchain one by one, so they leak far less than repeated on-chain payments. They are also faster and cheaper.

1. **Protect the device, not just the wallet.** A private payment means nothing on a compromised phone. Use a screen lock and a strong PIN, keep the phone updated, install apps only from official sources, and keep a separate, clean phone for sensitive work if you can.

1. **Use pseudonyms or a collective name for public fundraising.** Do not post real-time balances. Rotate any public donation address or, better, publish a Lightning address instead of a fixed on-chain address.

1. **Keep custody sane.** Write your seed phrase on paper or metal, store copies in two separate safe places, and never type it into a website or save it to the cloud or a photo. For a group's funds, use **multisig** (several people must agree to move money) so one seized phone or one arrest cannot drain the fund. Teach one trusted person how to recover funds if you cannot.

Scams and phishing: the fastest way to lose everything

Most losses are not government attacks. They are scams.

- **If anyone asks for your seed phrase or private key, it is a scam.** Always.

No wallet, exchange, educator or donor ever needs it.

- Be suspicious of "your wallet is locked, click to restore" messages, fake wallet links on WhatsApp or Telegram, and anyone impersonating a known donor.
- Bookmark the real wallet and exchange sites; do not follow links to them.
- Ignore "double your Bitcoin", "guaranteed returns" and giveaway pages.

Cashing out and buying privately

Peer-to-peer trades (person to person) leak less than fully identity-verified (KYC) platforms, but they carry their own risks: meeting strangers, fraud, and local legal rules. Balance privacy, safety and the law. See

[../merchant-kit/cash-out-options.md](https://github.com/0x05b5/merchant-kit/blob/master/cash-out-options.md) for

the current per-country options, and always check what is legal where you are.

A word on privacy tools and the law

Some advanced privacy tools you may read about (on-chain "mixing" services) have been shut down or made legally risky in some countries, and the landscape changes fast. This course teaches the durable habits above rather than any single tool. Before using any specific tool, check that it still exists, that it is trustworthy, and that it is legal where you live. ****Nothing here is about evading legitimate law or hiding a crime.**** It is about ordinary people keeping the ability to organise, report and survive when financial systems are turned against them.

If a device is seized or you are detained

See the [team safety protocol](#) for what to do, who to contact, and how to make sure no single person's phone can expose the whole group's funds. Plan this **before** you need it.

One-line summary

Hold your own keys, never reuse an address, never share your seed, keep wallets separate, use Lightning for small payments, and protect your phone. Freedom without privacy is just exposure.

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